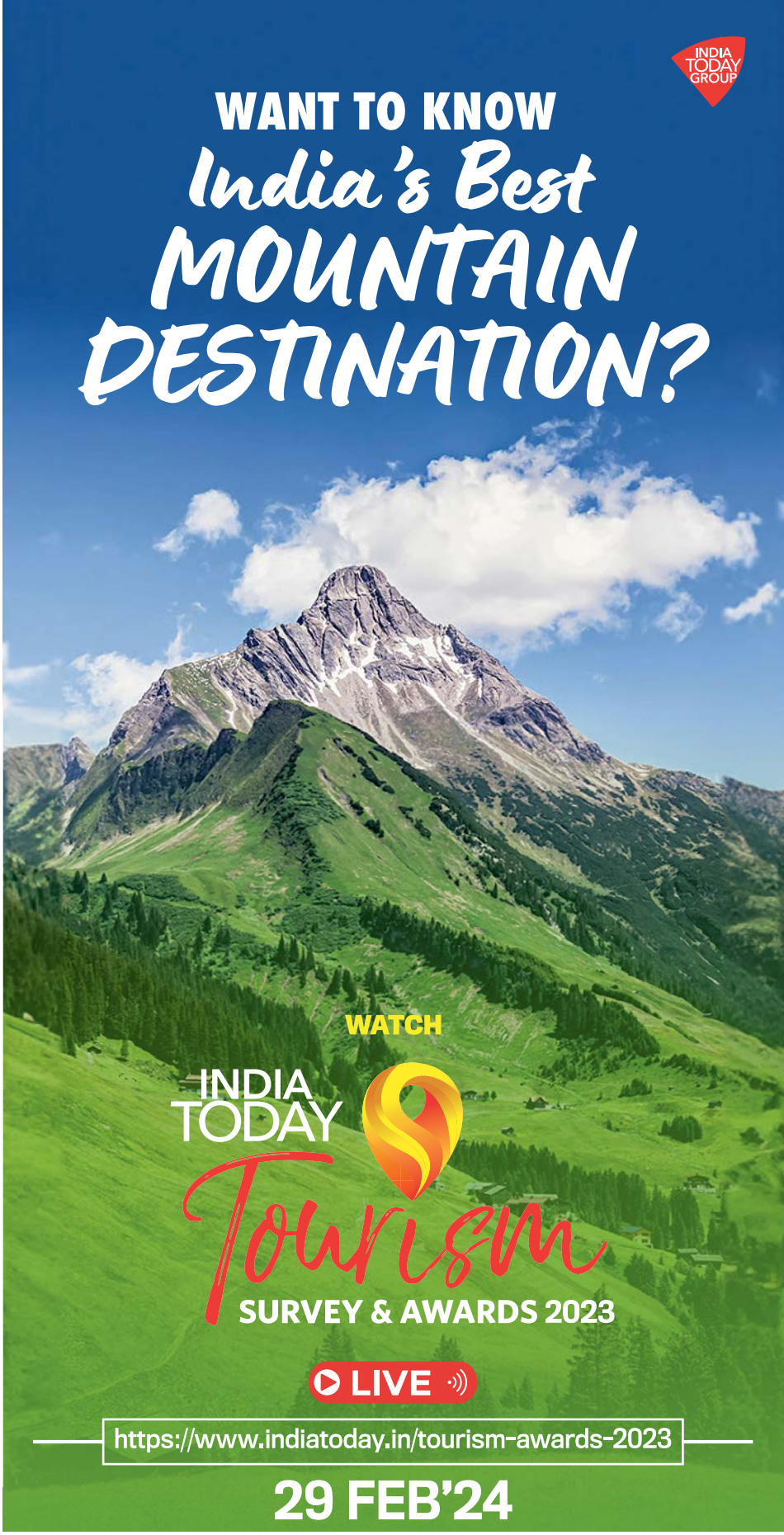
switching to the saffron side.

On February 12, Chavan resigned from all Congress posts and as the MLA from Bhokar constituency. A day later, the 65-year-old Maratha leader joined the BJP—the new affair was consummated on Valentine's Day, when he was seamlessly nominated to the Rajya Sabha. Chavan fell from grace with the Adarsh Housing Scam, once a pet theme for the BJP, but never quite lost his sway over Nanded, his stronghold in Marathwada.

The exit of the two-time CM—son of Shankarrao Chavan, himself a two-time CM and Gandhi family loyalist—is viewed as a big loss for the Congress. It comes at a time when the party is grappling with existential challenges. Over the past decade, the BJP has pursued a strategy of poaching prominent figures and their kin from the Congress, not only to bolster its own ranks but also to create awkward situations for the Gandhi family. Examples abound: in Punjab, the BJP welcomed the daughter of former CM Captain Amarinder Singh into its state unit after Singh hopped to the BJP fold, while Saurabh, the son of former Uttarakhand CM Vijay Bahuguna who had deserted the Congress to join the BJP, is a minister in the Pushkar Singh Dhami government. Similarly, in Goa, ex-CM Pratapsingh Rane retired at the behest of his son Viswajit Rane, who joined the BJP and is now a minister in the Pramod Sawant cabinet. Another former Congress CM of the state, Ravi Naik, is the agriculture minister.

Former CMs who have parted ways with the Congress often attribute their departure to a disconnect with the central leadership (read the Gandhi family), surrounded by "advisors" who make them inaccessible. They have also lamented a lack of reliance on grassroots leaders. In April last year, former Jammu and Kashmir CM Ghulam Nabi Azad made the candid assertion in his memoir, *Azaad*, that politicians have to be "spineless to survive in today's Congress". Many Congress ex-CMs, now painted anew in safe shades of saffron, would agree. ■



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